THE PRACTICAL MINI GUIDE

Your first week in Switzerland

A practical mini guide to documents, insurance, work and everyday life after moving.



Inside this guide

Your address, municipality and residence status / Understanding health coverage / Banking and everyday costs

GOOD TO KNOW

01 Your address, municipality and residence status

After moving, your municipality — Gemeinde or commune — becomes the main local contact. Its residents office explains address registration, supporting documents and appointments. Address registration and a residence document serve different purposes. People with Status S also need to understand their canton assignment: accommodation, support and some administrative matters may be linked to that canton. Proof of accommodation, identity documents and letters from the responsible service help the office understand the situation without repeated requests.

02 Understanding health coverage

Basic health insurance is handled separately from address registration. With Status S, a responsible service may already arrange coverage; starting another policy without clarification can create confusion. For people choosing their own insurance, the official Priminfo service compares premiums. The premium is only one part of the cost: the deductible, cost sharing and care model affect how the policy works. The confirmed coverage start date and insurer’s evidence matter more than simply having submitted an application.

GOOD TO KNOW

03 Banking and everyday costs

Each bank sets its document requirements with your residence situation in mind. Beyond monthly account fees, currency conversion, international transfers, cash withdrawals and card conditions affect the total price. A household budget includes housing, health insurance, food, transport and mobile service. A rental deposit and the first bills may fall in the same period, so the visible account balance is not necessarily spare money. Written fee schedules make it easier to compare offers on the same basis.

04 Transport and mobile service

For regular travel, the actual route and fare zones are more useful than the name of a travel pass alone. Urban transport, intercity trains and mountain lifts may follow different ticket conditions. Mobile offers also involve more than the advertised monthly price: activation, contract length, roaming and cancellation affect the overall cost. Switzerland is outside the EU, so an operator’s European roaming allowance should not be assumed to include Switzerland. The conditions of the specific plan determine what is covered.

GOOD TO KNOW

05 Work, school and local support

Permission to work depends on your residence document and the applicable procedure. Address registration alone does not establish that permission. Employment and self-employment may involve different administrative requirements; the competent cantonal service can explain the relevant route. Questions about school, local language courses and family support often begin with the municipality. Private childcare has its own availability and fees. Understanding the actual cost and confirmed availability of a place helps families plan work schedules realistically.

06 Understanding letters and decisions

An official confirmation, a submitted application and an appointment booking are different things. Sending a form does not by itself mean that a permit has been approved or insurance has started. A case reference, submission date and authority name help you trace correspondence. Documents containing personal information belong in a private folder rather than a public group chat. When two services appear to give different instructions, a written response from the responsible authority provides a more reliable basis for the next enquiry.

Good to know

After moving, your municipality — Gemeinde or commune — becomes the main local contact. Its residents office explains address registration, supporting documents and appointments. Address registration and a residence document serve different purposes. People with Status S also need to understand their canton assignment: accommodation, support and some administrative matters may be linked to that canton. Proof of accommodation, identity documents and letters from the responsible service help the office understand the situation without repeated requests.

Sources and useful links

ch.ch / Moving to Switzerland

BAG / Health insurance

Priminfo

SEM / Ukraine

The procedure depends on residence documentation, activity and location. The primary sources below help clarify the requirements for your circumstances.

Explore more on Sweezy